

THE FROZEN CONTINENT

Antarctica

Entirely surrounded by the Southern Ocean, Antarctica is the most remote continent. South America and Australia are 600 miles (1,000 km) and 1,600 miles (2,500 km) away respectively—but it wasn't always so isolated. Antarctica was part of the Gondwana supercontinent 200 million years ago, before it broke away to drift and settle at the South Pole some 35 million years ago.

The Antarctic Ice Sheet is the world's largest, averaging over 1 mile (1.6 km) thick—and weighing so heavily on the rock beneath that some parts have been pushed 1½ miles (2.5 km) below sea level. Antarctica is divided into two parts, East and West, separated by the Transantarctic Mountains. To the east, an enormous, flat plateau of ice overlies the ancient continental shield. To the west, the icescape and geology are more varied and have much in common with the South American Andes.



KEY DATA

▲ **Highest point** Mount Vinson:
16,066 ft (4,897 m)

● **Hottest record** Esperanza
Base: 63.5°F (17.5°C)

▼ **Lowest point** Bentley Subglacial
Trench: -8,327 ft (-2,538 m)

● **Coldest record** East
Antarctica: -139°F (-95°C)

CLIMATE

Antarctica is the coldest continent; 99 percent of its land is covered by ice, and freezing temperatures persist all year. High winds can cause violent snowstorms that may last for days.

AVERAGE TEMPERATURE

AVERAGE RAINFALL

